Consumer Complaints Analytics — CFPB Database

A SQL-driven analysis of ~16 million consumer financial complaints (Dec 2011 – Jun 2026)

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Context

The U.S. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau (CFPB) publishes every consumer complaint it receives about financial products — covering banks, credit reporting agencies, debt collectors, mortgage servicers, and student-loan servicers. The Complaint Database is the canonical regulatory dataset for measuring how financial institutions respond to consumer issues, and is the input for analyst teams in second-line-of-defense and complaints-management functions at U.S. lenders.

This case study analyzes the full ~16 million-row CFPB database using DuckDB SQL, focusing on five questions: (1) where complaints drop off in the resolution funnel; (2) which products underperform on responsiveness; (3) how individual financial institutions rank on combined risk metrics; (4) how complaint volumes and outcomes have shifted over time; and (5) how channel and geography affect resolution. The output is a portable set of SQL queries plus this case study summarizing findings and implications.

Methodology

The raw CFPB CSV was loaded into a local DuckDB instance (DuckDB v1.5.4) and cast into a cleaned base table — normalizing column names, casting dates, and computing a derived routing-time field (days between receipt and routing). All downstream analyses query this base table using CTEs, window functions (RANK), and conditional aggregation. Stage percentages are computed against the full receipt denominator (not the prior stage), so each metric is interpretable on its own.

The funnel is defined as: received → routed → responded → timely → resolved (where resolution is defined as a company response of "Closed with explanation", "Closed with monetary relief", or "Closed with non-monetary relief"). The "Consumer disputed?" field was deprecated by the CFPB in 2017 and is excluded.

Resolution Funnel

Stage	Count	% of received	Drop-off
Received	15,952,318	100.00%	—
Routed to company	15,952,318	100.00%	0.00%
Company responded	15,322,740	96.05%	3.95%
Responded timely	15,851,141	99.37%	—
Closed with resolution	15,252,782	95.61%	4.39%

The headline finding: routing and timeliness are near-perfect (96–100%), but ~4% of complaints — roughly 630,000 cases — never receive a company response at all. Companies that respond do so on time 99.4% of the time, so the gap is not a speed problem but a coverage problem: some complaints are not being closed out at all.

Product-Level Insights

- Student loans and payday loans lag the rest of the system: timely-response rates of 90.6% and 89.4% respectively, vs. 99%+ for credit reporting. Average routing also takes 3–7 days vs. <1 day for credit reporting.
- Credit reporting is 66% of all volume (~10.5M complaints) but 5.77% never receive a response — roughly 610,000 ignored complaints, the single largest pool of unresolved cases in the dataset.
- Credit cards have the highest relief-granted rate among major products at 33.1%, suggesting issuers actively settle complaints when they receive them. Mortgage, by contrast, grants relief only 7.4% of the time despite being one of the slowest-routing products.

Time-Series Shift: Volume Growth and Resolution Decline

Monthly complaint volume has risen from ~25k–48k per month in 2020 to ~668k per month by May 2026 — a ~15x increase over six years, with the steepest acceleration occurring in 2025–26. Untimely-response rates have stayed below 1% throughout, indicating the regulatory plumbing has scaled to keep pace.

The more concerning shift is in resolution outcomes. The share of complaints closed with monetary or non-monetary relief peaked at ~48% in late 2024 and has fallen to ~15% by mid-2026. Companies are responding faster and on time, but resolving fewer complaints in the consumer's favor — closing them with explanation rather than action. From a complaints-analytics perspective, this is a leading indicator: it suggests companies have absorbed the volume operationally but are settling fewer cases substantively, which is the kind of pattern a second-line-of-defense function would want to monitor.

Company-Level Risk Ranking & American Express Benchmark

Ranking all institutions with at least 1,000 complaints by combined untimely + no-response score surfaces a concentration of risk in student-loan servicing (MOHELA, EdFinancial) and debt collection (Capital Accounts, Professional Recovery Management). MOHELA in particular shows 31% untimely and 4.5% no-response on 27k complaints — patterns consistent with widely reported regulatory scrutiny of student-loan servicing.

American Express benchmarks favorably against its direct peer set:

Company	Complaints	Untimely %	No-resp %	Relief %	Days route
Bank of America	180,736	2.42	1.29	28.06	3.40
Wells Fargo	169,494	2.25	0.33	18.31	1.77
JPMorgan Chase	169,219	0.06	0.17	17.83	1.47
Capital One	162,635	0.05	0.58	19.49	1.19
Citibank	135,471	0.27	0.34	35.54	1.97
American Express	**57,170**	**0.26**	**0.23**	**28.93**	**1.20**
Discover Bank	44,502	0.03	0.00	27.90	0.91

Amex sits at roughly one-third the complaint volume of Bank of America, Wells Fargo, and JPMorgan Chase. It grants relief in 28.9% of cases — above JPMorgan (17.8%), Capital One (19.5%), and Wells Fargo (18.3%), and comparable to Bank of America (28.1%) and Citibank (35.5%). Average routing time is 1.20 days, second only to Discover. The visible opportunity is timely-response consistency: at 0.26%, Amex is roughly 5x higher than JPMorgan's 0.06% — a small absolute gap but the metric the SLOD function would naturally focus on.

Channel and Geography

- Web channel handles 96% of all complaints (15.3M of 16M), routes in 0.48 days vs. 3–7 days for phone, postal, and email, and resolves with relief 35.8% of the time vs. 13–21% for legacy channels. Channel modernization is doing the heavy lifting.
- Geographic distribution tracks population (FL, TX, CA, GA, NY lead by volume), and relief rates cluster tightly between 34–38% across all top states — suggesting company response policies are national rather than regional.

Implications for a Complaints Analytics Function

A complaints analytics team in a second-line-of-defense or risk function would naturally watch four signals from this data: (1) absolute volume trajectory by product, since the ~15x post-2020 growth changes operational baselines; (2) the resolution-mix shift — the post-2024 decline in monetary / non-monetary relief is the kind of pattern that can precede regulatory action; (3) per-institution outlier behavior on no-response rate, since that is where companies are quietly absorbing complaints without closing them; and (4) channel substitution, since the speed and outcome gap between web and legacy channels suggests a clear modernization lever.

From an issuer-specific perspective, an Amex SLOD analyst would likely want to (a) decompose the 0.26% untimely-response rate by product and sub-issue to identify the categories driving it; (b) benchmark Amex's resolution-mix evolution against peers over the same 2024–26 window where the broader market saw a relief-rate decline; and (c) track top complaint themes by sub-issue (e.g., charge disputes, rewards, account closure) for early signal on emerging issues.

Data source: CFPB Consumer Complaint Database (15,952,318 rows, Dec 2011 – Jun 2026) | Stack: DuckDB SQL | Repository: github.com/<user>/complaints-analytics